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An alter-native cultural imaginary of Brunei Darussalam in Tina Afiqah's *The Bubble Princess and the Stone Heart*

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ABSTRACT
This article examines the relationship between movement and place-making within the context of Brunei Darussalam through a literary analysis of the young adult novel *The Bubble Princess and the Stone Heart* by Tina Afiqah. The article argues for an alter-native cultural imaginary that transcends sociocultural prescriptions, framing mobility as a traversing of localities that shapes native cultural identities. The novel foregrounds embodied and emplaced mobilities to reimagine the place(less)ness of historical Poni, while simultaneously tracing cultural fluidity to reveal the transformative potential of movement across both terrestrial and non-terrestrial spaces. Mobility in the novel not only defines and produces Poni, but also enables relational processes of identity negotiation. By deploying mobility as a critical trope, Afiqah inscribes an alter-native cultural imaginary that resists cultural insularity and disrupts gender hierarchies. Ultimately, this analysis argues for an inclusive model of nation formation that subverts entrenched social hierarchies.

KEYWORDS
Alter-native; anglophone Bruneian fiction; cultural inclusion; mobilities; shifting localities; Tina Afiqah

Introduction: Rethinking cultural imaginaries through inclusivity and mobility

A collective imaginary shapes social life and informs the group dynamics among inhabitants of a place (Salazar 2011a, 11; see also Vandevoordt et al. 2018). Unlike the individual imagination, which is rooted in personal perception and subjectivity (Frank 2017, 18), the cultural imaginary refers to a shared expression of, and adherence to, cultural attitudes and processes that contribute to socially constructed identities, including notions of native belonging. As an ideological construct, the cultural imaginary is not fixed; it is shaped by power, continuously contested, and contextually contingent. Within a national framework, these imaginaries are often influenced by state-sanctioned narratives that inscribe particular versions of cultural consciousness, thus configuring how people imagine themselves and their relationship to place. As Charles Taylor (2004) observes, the cultural imaginary "is not so much expressed in theoretical terms, as it is carried in images, stories, and legends" (23). As a product of material culture, literature serves as a vital site for engaging with cultural imaginaries, whether state-sponsored or

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positioned as alternatives to dominant national narratives. In the context of contemporary anglophone Bruneian literature, an engagement with myth becomes a means of unpacking and reimagining the cultural imaginary, allowing for the articulation of more inclusive narratives of belonging. Borrowing from Taylor's concept of the modern social imaginary, this article examines Tina Afiqah's (2021) debut young adult (YA) novel *The Bubble Princess and the Stone Heart* to explore how ordinary people "imagine" their sociocultural relations in ways that challenge prescriptive forms of indigeneity and cultural exclusion, moving instead towards more inclusive and fluid models of identity.

In her essay "The Imaginary", Claudia Strauss (2006) states that imaginaries often tend towards "cultural abstraction, reification, and homogenization" (322). Building on this, Denise Jodelet (2014) identifies place as a repository for identity projections, which helps illuminate how Poni – the imaginary territory in Afiqah's novel – operates. *The Bubble Princess* narrates mobile trajectories of mythical figures and human characters from "Poni" (Afiqah 2021, 1), who grapple with an imaginary shaped by cultural otherness. Poni, also known as Boni (Kurz 2023, 81), is historically the name for Brunei Darussalam (henceforth Brunei), and it functions in the novel as an ideologically contested space where mobility enables the mapping of more inclusive identities for Bruneian inhabitants claiming this locality as their home. What is now Brunei used to comprise a multicultural and multi-religious society, shaped by the cultural and political influences of Hindu-Buddhist kingdoms across the Indonesian archipelago, particularly the thalassocratic Majapahit Empire of Java. As Afiqah notes, "it was also under the influence of the kingdom's thalassocracy (and its 'thalassocratic' beliefs) that water became the vessel which conducted many legends, myths and especially *magic*" (2021, 1; emphasis in original). This observation points to a cultural affiliation with water that dates back to historical Brunei, when the polity was still known as Poni. By confronting the forces of cultural homogenization, the novel advances hybrid and heterogeneous identities. It reworks the "imaginary of cultural otherness" (Jodelet 2014, 19.1) by foregrounding cultural fluidity and inclusive belonging. *The Bubble Princess* portrays representations of local folklore and myth that trace movements across geographical landforms and bodies of water to address, among other concerns, ethnic marginalization and patriarchal constraint. Evoking the thalassocratic cultures of Southeast Asia, the novel draws on experiences of mobility to challenge land-based nativism and its static claims to belonging – claims often reinforced by male-dominated power structures within patriarchal state ideologies. By undoing fixed relations between place and mobility, this article interrogates essentialist identities tied to fixed geographical locations, while also exploring more fluid and relational forms of identity.

Borrowing from Noel Salazar's use of "alter-native" (2011b, 580; 2023, 90; see also Astudillo and Salazar 2024, 187), this article engages a cultural imaginary that transcends state-sanctioned normative boundaries. Foregrounding an alter-native cultural heritage that "has not yet been memorialized in guidebooks and official histories" (Salazar 2011b, 580), Afiqah's novel resonates with Salazar's call to disentangle dominant narratives from essentialist notions of rootedness. I employ the hyphenated term "alter-native" to denote an alternative perspective on native identity, one shaped by a cultural imaginary that diverges from state-driven, authority-defined constructions of locality and belonging. In this reading of the novel, Salazar's concept of mobility functions as a counterpoint to official scripts of cultural insularity, disrupting dominant land-based nativist discourses.

In the Bruneian context, such discourses manifest in a state-crafted narrative of national unity upheld through racial and gender-based practices that limit sociocultural inclusion.[1] In Brunei, dominant national identity is constructed through male- and Malay-centric frames of reference that legitimize the national ideology of the Malay Muslim Monarchy (Deterding & Ho 2021; Hadi 2020). This ethnonationalist framework reinforces racial and gender binaries "supported by the Islamic and monarchic components of the national ideology" (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2019, 149), undergirding cultural exclusion and patriarchal power. Moreover, the deployment of political Islam, as distinct from theological Islam, functions as a strategic ideological apparatus that informs state ideologies and structures social life (Croissant 2022).

Concomitant with the dominant discourse of nativism, Brunei's rapid modernization led to a unidirectional migration from water to land (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2020, 2021b, 2023). Historically, the British Protectorate system (1888–1984) introduced a form of colonial patriarchy (Kumpoh et al. 2022; Leigh 2018), which operated alongside an indigenous patriarchy wherein Malay Muslim male chiefs were vested with authority over local ethnic and religious matters. In 1909, the British Resident McArthur used his political influence to move the administrative capital called Kampung Ayer ("Water Village") to a land-based settlement in Bandar Seri Begawan, Brunei's current capital. The move initiated a pattern of relocation that persisted throughout the reign of the 28th Sultan of Brunei from 1950 to 1967 (Muhammad et al. 2017). Afiqah's post-British Protectorate-era novel is an example of how Southeast Asian postcolonial literature in English serves as a potent platform for rewriting notions of natives-in-place. It offers an alternative narrative of locality that incorporates mobility as a fundamental concept in reconfiguring the cultural imaginary of the native peoples in a nation. Afiqah's work challenges state-sanctioned narratives of native identity and deconstructs cultural hierarchies rooted in ethnic and gender differentiations. Crucially, *The Bubble Princess* advances an alter-native approach to native identity by collapsing boundaries that traditionally rely on insularity and protectionist social cohesion. The novel blurs distinctions between native/Malay and non-native/non-Malay identities, fostering inclusive relations rather than perpetuating social hierarchies through native identity.

This article explores how Afiqah's novel reclaims water from the periphery, despite its absence in state discourse as a space associated with non-native and non-Malay identities, offering a counterpoint through an alter-native cultural imaginary that contests state-driven reforms and ideological constructions of native identity. Accordingly, its key intervention lies in articulating an alter-native cultural stance towards native identity, envisioning a counter-imaginary that challenges fixed notions of a static home and closed definitions of Bruneian identity. This article adopts a two-pronged approach to race and gender by analysing the intersection of racial and gender hierarchies within the Bruneian nation, alongside its active pursuit of cultural localization (Ho 2021a). Mobility serves as a critical unit of analysis to contest rigid boundaries in Brunei's sociocultural landscape and to explore the cultural possibilities that arise through movement and migration.

Anglophone Bruneian literature: Rewriting "natives-in-place"

Afiqah's novel traces the journey of the eponymous water-borne princess, Cordelia ("Lia"), whose encounters with fishermen evoke maritime routes and water-dependent

livelihoods that shape identities and cultures in Poni. By naming the protagonist after Cordelia from Shakespeare's *King Lear*, Afiqah invokes a marginalized female figure whose unwavering loyalty to a larger collective persists despite her exile to social peripheries. In doing so, the novel foregrounds Lia's resistance to patriarchal structures and cultural exclusions within Poni. *The Bubble Princess* makes a significant reconnection to Brunei's aquatic heritage by engaging with water-based ecologies as integral to Bruneian cultural consciousness. Brunei's watery origins are central to its foundational mythology (deVienne 2011, 2019), a theme amplified in Afiqah's novel through the portrayal of a fish queen and her "baeda" subjects, including Lia, who are mythological figures emerging from the seas of Poni.

Historically, Poni was a backwater fishing village composed of provincial communities (Kurz 2014), a setting reflected in the novel's opening scenes, where the omniscient narrator introduces a group of fishermen (Afiqah 2021, 5–7). The novel briefly references Poni's historical role as a Southeast Asian trading port (Kurz 2014), alluding to "foreigners from a distant land" (Afiqah 2021, 11) who arrive to trade. Thus the novel engages with historical records of Chinese traders, or *hua qiao* (Chinese sojourners) (Ho 2021b), who conducted barter trade with local fishermen. The continued influx of Chinese migrants led to the establishment of multiple generations of Chinese diaspora in Brunei (Debbie G.E. Ho and Hannah M.Y. Ho 2021). However, Brunei-born Chinese remain excluded from the status of *rakyat jati* (indigenous citizens), due to their exclusion from the state-sanctioned Malay identity, which includes only seven ethnic groups: Brunei Malay, Tutong, Belait, Kedayan, Bisaya, Dusun, and Murut (Brunei Nationality Act [1961] 2002). Despite this exclusion, hybrid Chinese Malay families and Muslim converts exemplify how Malay Muslim norms, or the social and religious standards prescribed by male Muslim authorities, are adapted and shaped in the Bruneian context (Sahrifulhafiz & Hoon 2018), while simultaneously highlighting the fluidity of religious and cultural boundaries. Through its engagement with Poni's maritime past and multi-ethnic present, Afiqah's novel foregrounds the cultural and historical significance of Brunei's water-based communities, challenging rigid definitions of native identity.

As part of an emergent body of anglophone Bruneian literature, *The Bubble Princess* contributes to a broader trend in postcolonial writing that engages both local and global audiences. It was published in Brunei and distributed both locally and internationally, reflecting its dual audience. While anglophone Bruneian fiction often targets a transnational readership (Mohd Daud 2025), Afiqah's novel centres on a mythical retelling of Poni's sociocultural landscape that resonates strongly with local readers, in particular, with a growing demographic of English-speaking and English-educated Bruneian youth who are attuned to global discourses on diversity, inclusion, and mobility, yet remain grounded in local cultural frameworks. The novel's use of myth functions as a narrative strategy to avoid local censorship mechanisms that regulate print media (George & Venkiteswaran 2019). This strategic deployment of myth as an allegorical device to circumnavigate censorship that might constrain more direct and factual writing also appears in other anglophone Bruneian works, such as Aammton Alias's (2016, 2019, 2023) *The Bunian Conspiracy Series* and Kathrina Mohd Daud's (2020) *The Fisherman King*, the latter likewise revisiting historical Poni to explore identity formation across land and water. In these literary texts, folklore becomes a crucial repository through which writers challenge dominant national narratives. The prominence of myth and

folklore in anglophone Bruneian literature points to the enduring vitality of oral storytelling traditions that resist easy alignment with written histories or state-regulated cultural imaginaries. Instead, these texts mobilize myth to forge a more inclusive and pluralistic cultural imaginary of the nation (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2020, 2025a).

An alter-native discourse emerges in *The Bubble Princess*, where the use of allegory employs the trope of mobility to reconceptualize native identity beyond static, sedentary, and racially fixed determinants. As a contemporary literary text, it resonates with Bruneian readers by engaging global concerns around inclusivity and diversity. Hannah Ming Yit Ho and Rinni Haji Amran (2021) observe that the theme of mobility in several anglophone Bruneian novels "signal[s] participation in a global, rather than local, discourse" (166). However, Afiqah's novel simultaneously engages with local nation-building by positioning Poni as an "imagined community" (Anderson [1983] 2006), oriented towards an ideological vision of horizontal comradeship. Such alternative visions of the nation are explored through inclusive frameworks that seek to integrate marginalized communities in anglophone Bruneian literary works (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2020, 2021b, 2023). Hannah M.Y. Ho (2025a) argues that "alter notions of identity, culture, and nation" offer a critique of "powers that disrupt belonging in the home" (112). In this context, decolonial representations of native culture encourage a rethinking of racial hierarchies and foreground hybrid identities that "undo oriental myths of the indigenous other" (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2024, 238). In *The Bubble Princess*, movements across water signify not merely physical displacement (Hannah M.Y. Ho 2021b, 2024, 2025b) but, more significantly, cultural mobility – an act that disrupts normative frameworks of identity and belonging.

Land-based nativism is similarly rejected in favour of more fluid identities, which are informed by marine ecologies and articulate a form of water-based nativism. Bruneian literatures in English, as exemplified in Afiqah's novel, also transcend the boundaries imposed by official discourses that prioritize the Malay language and reinforce a Malay-centric cultural imaginary. Within this framework, YA fiction emerges as a vital site for engaging with cultural and political discourses of native identity. It offers a reimagining of the cultural and social structures into which one is expected to assimilate. The novel constructs a world of possibility that interrogates both physical and social boundaries, using historical imagination to chart the journeys of characters who traverse both land and sea. While scholarly criticism of anglophone Southeast Asian literature rarely includes YA fiction, its presence in anglophone Bruneian writing exemplifies a shift towards engaging younger generations, both as target readership and as authors shaped by Brunei's bilingual education system which uses both Malay and English language (Salbrina et al. 2024). Despite the system's emphasis on cultivating both local and global identities, Malay remains the official language, reinforcing a linguistic and cultural hierarchy (David and Ho 2021). Within Brunei's growing literary scene, anglophone writing fosters critical engagement beyond this status quo.

In this way, *The Bubble Princess* presents a critique of present-day cultural hierarchies through the temporal lens of an imagined past. The novel invites critical attention for its depiction of local identities via the trope of mobility, illustrated through the characters' voluntary and involuntary movements across land and water. At the same time, it engages with immobility at key moments in the princess's life as she becomes emplaced within Poni. By engaging with local discourses of native identity, Afiqah's novel suggests

that native identity entails a socially recognized sense of belonging, with cultural boundaries of locality extending beyond prescriptive norms established by dominant identity discourses. In doing so, the narrative enacts a critical rewriting of the concept of natives-in-place, positioning mobility as a central to reconfiguring and rethinking place-based identity. Alter-native subjects traverse and inhabit Poni in ways that activate mobilities, thus advancing a discourse of cultural inclusivity.

Articulating an alter-native cultural imaginary in *The Bubble Princess and the Stone Heart*

The Bubble Princess is replete with metaphors of magic and fairytale figures, including a bubble princess, a fish queen, swashbuckling pirates, and mythical sea creatures. These folkloric and fantastical elements are generatively framed as part of a counter-imaginary that resists dominant national narratives. The notable absence of a Malay Muslim lineage on which Brunei's cultural imaginary has traditionally been constructed signals a deliberate literary counter-response. Instead, the novel centres on an ethnically ambiguous bubble princess whose interactions with a pirate king and non-human "baedas" advance a more inclusive vision of belonging through the forging of an alter-native cultural imaginary.

The protagonist is a young girl-creature identified as a "baeda" who is native to the waters surrounding Poni's land. Gifted to a human fisherman by the Fish Queen, Lia is raised under the tutelage of Babah (a Malay colloquialism denoting "father"). Initially, she is confined in Babah's house, restricting her mobility as she follows his well-meaning advice to stay indoors and avoid hostile human villagers. However, she eventually sets out to travel beyond her house and village when urged on by "a liberated spirit" (Afiqah 2021, 30) named Gil, a shape-shifting jellyfish who becomes Lia's travel companion and best friend, revealing to her "the world [she has] been missing out on" (31). As they travel between villages, Gil evokes the past harmony between humans and baedas, reflecting with hope: "Perhaps the villagers have learnt to accept people for their differences?" (47). In reality, the villagers' persistent social exclusion erodes Lia's sense of belonging to Poni, and corrodes the usual mutual respect between the different peoples inhabiting the same place within the communal home. As a result of human villagers' depreciation and disparagement of baedas designed to legitimize their social hierarchy in Poni, the "child's melancholy" (41) is a signifier for Lia's emotional distress due to prescriptive native identity from which she is excluded. The sea of permeability and fluidity where Lia was born contrasts with land-based villagers' rigid intolerance that moors native identity to fixed cultural definitions.

The Bubble Princess narrates the story of humans and baedas as a sociocultural allegory that explores themes of displacement, exclusion, and identity. The novel depicts the ambivalent ties between Malays and non-Malays living in proximity. From an ethno-racial perspective, the human villagers assume a self-privileging status that reflects Malay ethnonational dominance. In contrast, the shape-shifting baedas who are ostracized on land are forced to retreat to the waters of Poni. Whilst the land-based human villagers are masculinized and represent a closed, exclusionary culture, the water-borne baedas, governed by the Fish Queen and embracing a more open vision of home, are feminized, bringing a gendered dimension alongside the racial. Their exclusion reflects broader

anxieties around cultural purity and native identity, which is regulated by the villagers as exclusively land-based. It is this imbalance that motivates Lia's journey across Poni's land and waters, as her mobility facilitates cultural transformation and challenges dominant hierarchies by forging a more inclusive and collective home.

Consequently, Afiqah's novel transcends social divisions by blurring the distinction between an open culture which is aligned with feminized, water-based identities, and a closed culture associated with masculinized, land-based identities. By reimagining local identity through the interconnectedness of baedas and human communities, the novel forges an inclusive narrative in which mobility becomes a critical trope for contesting ethnocentric and land-based constructions of place-based identity. Through this strategy, an alter-native cultural imaginary emerges to challenge exclusionary ideologies of cultural otherness and dismantle the construction of "natives-in-place".

Embodied mobilities as a framework for racial inclusion

Lia and other water creatures embody mobilities that are both involuntary, marked by a banishment to Poni's waters by territorial humans, and voluntary, reflecting a conscious decision to migrate to land. When Babah fails to return home from a fishing trip, Lia embarks on a journey across land and water to bring him home before permanently choosing to live on land. The narrative about Lia begins with an introduction to an idyllic social scene: "There was a time – when Poni had been more land than water – the baeda co-existed peacefully alongside the human villagers" (Afiqah 2021, 2), a connection that is reflected in the tender relations between the land-based Babah and water-borne Lia. Their affective ties are evident in their relationship as when

> Babah also [..] told the young girl many stories about baeda and magic – her favourite tale being the one about the Fish Queen and of how Lia herself had just been a seemingly common bubble when the Queen gave her to Babah. (21)

Babah reveals his awareness of the social discrimination baedas face from his own people when he implores her to stay at home, saying "this little baeda has to stay indoors" (22). He explains to her that this confinement is "because the other villagers are not yet ready for change". He adds: "I fear they might not be as accepting towards your differences as I have been" (22). His ambivalence frames Lia's immobility in her early years as a defence mechanism against the stigma of belonging to baedas. However, the narrator also points out that "Babah understood that a life trapped indoors – particularly, a friendless life – would be no proper life for a child" (23), thus acknowledging the dilemma in Babah's decision. While constraining her social development, this immobility shielded her from harm.

When she is 12 years old, Lia contravenes Babah's counsel to stay in the house by stepping out and exploring the village. She experiences several offensive encounters with human villagers, including a Malay native boy or "Babu's boy", as Lia calls him, whose physical features are described as having "the colour of warm cinnamon and honey" and his hair as "curled into wild, jet-black crinkles" (Afiqah 2021, 34). Due to her outward difference from them, the village children other Lia through taunts of "ugly" and "cursed" as she desperately defends herself by claiming "I'm no baeda! [...] I'm a villager" (Afiqah 2021, 38). By refuting her baeda origins, she attempts to carve out a native space for

herself in Babah's land-based village. However, she is met with Babu's boy's passive-aggressive remark when he pointedly asks: "You know what our ancestors did to baeda that roamed our lands? [...] They stoned them!" (39). As a gatekeeper of Malay native identity, Babu's boy invokes an Islamic punitive act of stoning to threaten the bubble princess birthed by the waters of Poni, rather than its land. Either unwittingly or intentionally negligent about Poni's dual land-water composition, the Babu's boy perpetuates a cultural imaginary that gravitates to a fixed, closed, and prescriptive definition of place and attendant ideas of indigeneity and belonging without accounting for the fluidity and mobility of local identities in Poni.

By treating baedas as "newcomers" (Afiqah 2021, 11), the human villagers actively construct and police the boundaries of native identity, reinforcing exclusionary social and cultural hierarchies. As the narrator recalls, there were instances in the past in which

> there had been occurrences where foreigners from distant lands would come to trade or to seek shelter, only to have the Poni villagers turning them away as they repeatedly mistook these foreigners (particularly those with blue eyes) for glowing-eyed baeda[s]. (11)

This conflation reveals how Poni villagers adopt a world view that essentializes racial and cultural differences in order to justify the exclusion of outsiders. Ronald Takaki's (1989) book, *Strangers from a Different Shore*, resonates here, as villagers expediently ascribe foreignness to baedas who are othered through a logic of racialized misrecognition. Takaki's theorization that dominant groups maintain social boundaries by denying full belonging to those they deem "others" illuminates the dynamics in Afiqah's novel. This dangerous stereotyping sustains a dominant cultural imaginary of native identity that relegates baedas to the social peripheries. The denial of social relations with baedas becomes evident when the narrator reflects on the limits of communal empathy: "Even at times when they [Poni villagers] showed the slightest glint of humanity or kindness towards each other, it was only ever amongst their own kind" (Afiqah 2021, 11). The omniscient narrator's statement underscores the villagers' refusal to extend basic recognition or compassion to those marked as outsiders, thereby reinforcing the boundaries of belonging. The villagers' selective friendliness reproduces a closed notion of native identity. In the cultural logic of the Poni villagers, mobility is cast in opposition to place and belonging; native identity is imagined as fixed and immobile.

In contrast, baedas emerging from the waters and embodying mobility in their fluid composition demonstrate a markedly different orientation – one rooted in openness, hospitality, and a willingness to engage in social encounters. Affective descriptions of Lia's "surge of sadness" and "misery" (Afiqah 2021, 39) exacerbate a conflicted belonging in her claim to native identity, which is disavowed by human villagers who ascribe alterity to her physiological features. Lia's melancholic mood can be read as a manifestation of the psychological and emotional toll imposed by hostile social environments. The aggression is epitomized in a village boy's mocking remark: "Poke her with your stick, why don't ya? Maybe, she'll pop!" (38), which underscores the ridicule and dehumanization that she endures. Nevertheless, Lia's choice of mobility affords her to learn about cultural divisions resulting from social hierarchies in anthropocentric and anthropogenic Poni. Through this embodied mobility, baedas not only assert their claim to belonging in Poni but also seek redress for the affective injuries of exclusion and discrimination endured within what they, too, regard as their communal home.

Baedas' embodied mobility is subsequently materialized through their affiliation with water, which symbolizes their fluid properties of mutability and resilience. Their mythical nature reinforces their liminal presence across the boundaries of land and sea, while also signalling experiences of lost land, home, and identity. Lia's return to the waters in search of her missing Babah leads to an encounter with a fellow baeda, whom she names Diri (translated as "Self"; Afiqah 2021, 167). Driven by the belief that "humans are cruel, humans are bad" (172), Diri enacts her vengeance by casting a spell on a group of seafaring villagers. This spell prevents them from leaving her island and returning to their families (165). As Aasim, one of her captives, recounts,

> the light [produced by the spell] was so great that I had to cover my eyes. When I opened them, he [another villager who tried leaving Diri's island] vanished. I was distraught as I lost a part of me that day. (159)

His loss arises from the obliteration of a fellow villager with whom he shared a community and home. Symbolically, the annihilation of human bodies speaks to their fragility of place and belonging and the power of the baedas in their own milieu. Diri's ability to unleash this devastation destabilizes the cultural imaginaries rooted in these geographies – her spell is both a response to human-driven displacement of baedas and an exposure of the fragility of the very imaginaries shaped by human communities. Her retaliation reveals how anthropogenic forces, those produced by human pressures on ecological and social systems, can disrupt environmental balances, displace populations, and erode social cohesion. These ruptures, in turn, generate profound affective losses of identity and belonging.

Amid this landscape of loss and dislocation, Lia's encounter with Diri provides a more intimate, psychological dimension to the narrative's exploration of identity. Diri can be read as a desolate avatar or a symbolic projection of what Lia might become were she to adopt a world view that casts humans as evil. As the embodiment of the titular "stone heart", Diri personifies emotional closure and alienation as she deliberately distances herself from Poni's human inhabitants. Driven by a desire to punish the villagers for having "misuse[d], misunderstand[ing], and misle[d] [baedas]" out of their human "greed" (Afiqah 2021, 172), she withdraws into solitude, seeking refuge in her lament. She slumbers and sings "deep beneath the crystal blue sea", simultaneously expressing sorrow and resistance in a lyrical elegy for losses inflicted by humans:

> *Where the moon don pass and the sun don rise*
> *Is a mortal-made home paradise*
> *Which scatters all past callous sins*
> *To an ancient song within the winds*
> (Afiqah 2021, 164; emphasis in original)

In denouncing human transgressions that produce a model of identity that judges whether or not people belong in racialized grounds, Diri indicts the villagers for having "exploit[ed] the eerie" and "misled the mystical", concluding that "humans do not deserve our forgiveness" (170) because they "care for nothing but themselves" (173), shown as they transform Poni into an anthropocentric landscape. Diri's disruption of the natural temporal cycle, on land and in waters stripped of the sun and moon, is how she imposes immobility upon humanity. This tension is mirrored in the villagers' rejection of

mobilities, which is crystallized in their adherence to "stagnancy and sameness" (11) and their refusal to accept baedas and their intrinsic place–mobility nexus.

The novel, therefore, critiques the villagers' authoritarian and anthropocentric world view, proposing instead the mobilities of the baedas as a counter-response that reimagines the binaries between land and water, human and baeda, parent and child. On the land of Poni, humans continue to enforce a cultural homogeneity that suppresses internal cultural and social mobility in an effort to preserve social cohesion amongst themselves. As the narrator observes,

> the villagers had reduced into mundane, ordinary brutes. They lived a life dependent on routine and repetition because to them, it was a risk*less* life to live. The villagers all walked, talked, thought and dressed the same; they had evolved (or devolved would be a more appropriate term!). (Afiqah 2021, 11; emphasis in original)

The artificial uniformity is imposed by the human villagers who subscribe to a socially constructed identity and who tolerate little diversity and few cultural variations to assert authority over those who are culturally and "linguistic[ally]" (13) different. Conversely, "*un*-ordinary" (27; emphasis in original) baedas rebuke this attitude.

Notwithstanding this, the novel offers a cautionary warning that the baedas' unethical imposition of a cultural imaginary risks replicating the same paradigm of social ostracization as the villagers based on cultural otherness. Lia highlights the dangers of Diri's own stereotyping of humans, which threatens to create a divided home grounded in authoritarian definitions of native identity. Through the imposition of involuntary immobility, the human captives become subjected to Diri's condemnation, which blinds her to the possibility of goodness in humanity. Lia attempts to challenge Diri's perspective, reminding her that "The very humans who you have kept in captivity; they have been the very ones who made your island beautiful" (Afiqah 2021, 171) and they "have filled your very island with laughter and joy, yet you discount their company all this time – especially when you've had no one else left in the world to call 'friend'" (174). Moreover, Lia underscores the symbolic significance of water when she states that "Bubbles hold memories" (170), a phrase that ties memory specifically to water as fluid, transient, and tied to a fragile place-based identity. Memories resist containment; they move across land and water through the mobile patterns of both humans and baedas. Despite her painful memories of being bullied on land, Lia observes new bubbles surfacing – one showing "the memory of Babah comforting his weeping child", and another depicting "the first night Babah, Lia and Gil spent together as a family" (171). Though ephemeral, these bubbles persist by existing as bubbles of water on land and bubbles of air underwater. These memory-bubbles, rising from the waters to which Lia returns and where she discovers Diri's island of human captives, serve as emblems of cultural imaginaries that are continually unmade, (de)constructed, and shaped by place, mobility, and sociocultural relations.

Therefore, Afiqah's novel enacts a rewriting of the concept of natives-in-place through the physical movements of baedas and humans across the land and waters of Poni, highlighting their shared similarities rather than differences. Lia's empathy for the human captives compels her to remain on Diri's island, eventually transforming into a human-like form, illustrated when "one single streak of red streamed out of her nose" marks a significant moment of transition, for the blood releases a "metallic

scent of smelt, of fragility, mortality, precariousness" (Afiqah 2021, 173). Smelting emphasizes how identities can transform, evoking an alter(ed) state that accommodates coexisting forms of selfhood. This is exemplified by Lia, whose hybrid baeda-human form is marked by bleeding, signalling the permeability of her transformed identity. This transformation signifies an alter-native imaginary, that is a reimagining of nativism for foregrounding commonalities between humans and baedas. Looking ahead to a future shaped by this "untold truth" (Afiqah 2021, 157), Lia chooses to continue living on land. Lia's migration to Babah's village as a young baeda, her symbolic homecoming to Diri's island, and her final decision to reside among the Poni villagers articulate an alter-native cultural imaginary which is defined by mobility and intercultural solidarity.

Mobility as a site for undoing the gender binary

The novel's narrative of mobilities also dismantles the gender binary by revealing how movement across spaces disrupts and reconfigures rigid gender identities between dominant men and subordinated women. To exemplify, a pirate king named Jaspir enacts his authority by immobilizing Lia. Prior to meeting Diri, Lia encounters the king who abducts Babu's boy, Gil, and her. He declares: "You WILL stay HERE, and ONLY when you agree to be my wife, you MAY join me upstairs [on the upper deck]!" (Afiqah 2021, 63; emphasis in original). King Jaspir demands Lia's subjugation via the use of modal auxiliary verbs, which add obligation and authorization to his ultimatum. King Jaspir confines Lia to an "inferior" hold of his ship:

> [He] took her down to a cold, dark room where there were cages dangling eerily from the rooftop. From afar, they looked like bird cages big enough to keep a fully-grown eagle, but far too small to keep even a half-matured human. (63)

Within this chamber, deteriorating bodies stand in for the "dead" (63) – passive, immobile, and lifeless – form of "baeda prisoners" (77) who are held against their will in these hanging enclosures. Although located on a sailing vessel that moves across the sea, Lia is paradoxically trapped in situ and unable to exercise her self-autonomy. Jaspir exercises his authority by immobilizing her. However, Lia makes her "great escape" (73) through her ability to shape-shift into bubbles. Her mobile, unfixed body as a shape-shifter enables her to unsettle the gender hierarchy that supports Jaspir's male-centric authority.

Similarly, the Fish Queen articulates an alter-native discourse of identity through her sovereign rule over the waters of Poni. Her depiction recalls the legendary Sundanese Queen of the Southern Sea, Nyi Roro Kidul – a fearsome mythical figure outlawed in modern Muslim beliefs – since the Fish Queen similarly evokes fear and respect over the waters and coasts of Poni. The latter subverts the myth of a Fish(erman) King who featured in the human villagers' stories

> about a great fish baeda. But this infamous fish baeda had always been portrayed as a rather "kingly" figure. "He" ruled all who inhabited the water and was believed to be the heart and force amongst all sea-life (and the *sea* itself!). (Afiqah 2021, 8; emphasis in original)

The use of male pronouns nullifies the existence of the Fish Queen and reinforces the human villagers' cultural imaginary of a masculinized narrative of authority over Poni. The dominant cultural imaginary that upholds the gender binary is assumed to be male by the human villagers. When speaking to Babah, the human fisherman, the Fish Queen repudiates this imposed norm: "It irks me to hear villagers speak of 'The Great Fish King'. Tell me, do I look 'kingly' to you?" (Afiqah 2021, 9). As the Fish Queen explicates, in order to go undetected as a baeda, and a female one at that, "[she] would visit Poni to observe the human villagers while masking herself in different forms" (9). Her mobility enables her both to govern her fish baedas and to move freely within the human world, where her self-presentation as a queen, rather than a king, challenges the villager's male-dominated framework of authority. Moreover, the Fish Queen "spoke in a voice that was feminine, low and majestic" (9). Her sovereign authority remains unattenuated by her female subjectivity. As the embodied voice of baedas and critical observer of human societal norms, the Fish Queen resists and subverts the human-constructed cultural imaginary of Poni.

Conclusion: Forging inclusivity in shifting localities

Migrations across water and land support an alter-native cultural imaginary in which land, traditionally associated with humans, is no longer closed off to non-humans, such as Lia and Gil's habitation of Babah's house. The water is also no longer uninhabited by humans, as when the waters become a permanent home for Aasim and other villagers, they choose to "keep [Diri's] island company" even after the spell is lifted (Afiqah 2021, 182). This two-way mobility enhances the friendship between humans and baedas, symbolized through the use of pathetic fallacy near the end of Lia's journey through Poni as "overhead, after the midnight clouds had casted, the sky began dripping with all the colours of the earth, and shimmers of the sea" (192). The sky's harmony merges the varied hues of land and water to signal an alter-native cultural imaginary that encapsulates inclusion, belonging, and mobility. Lia has lingering doubts as she approaches land again, asking "What do you think will happen once we get back to Poni? [...] Do we go back to being strangers?" (190), but Poni's radiance quells these. Lia reconciles with Babu's boy when they travel to Diri's island together after their abduction by King Jaspir. They plan to return to Poni's land together (192) and, en route, Lia is heartened by the Malay boy's promise of "a [birthday] present which he intended to give her when they returned to Poni but Lia assured him it was already the best birthday of all other birthdays" (191) because of their reconciliation, marking the moment when Lia overcomes the emotional pain that he had previously caused her. Their journey ends on a renewed note of triumph, as on her birthday "she didn't just celebrate another year of being alive, but she celebrated the company of her new friends" (192). Lia's newfound companionship, rooted in the old and familiar, signals a recalibrated confidence in reimagined narratives of native belonging. Reflecting on the art of storytelling as integral to identity-making, Lia's anticipation for "inventive [...] narratives" (188) in which "each story was never the same" (188) shows her embracing diachronous practices of identity-making. This narrative variation allows an engagement with embodied and emplaced mobilities as a means of defining those who live in, move through, and traverse Poni.

Lia's receptiveness to heterogeneous native identities serves as a pointed critique of the limitations inherent in a closed cultural imaginary.

Ultimately, *The Bubble Princess* constructs a counter-imaginary through its own narrative that embraces participatory forms of nativism, engaging the motif of mobility to challenge fixed ideas of place and identity, and thus fostering ethnically inclusive and interactive localities. Its use of water ecologies symbolically reflects the fluidity of belonging and identity, disrupting rigid binaries of race and gender. As a result, Afiqah's anglophone Bruneian YA novel offers a compelling reimagining of national inclusion for socially and gender-marginalized communities.

Notes

1. While distinctions between race and ethnicity are debated, this article treats them synonymously to emphasize shared experiences of marginalization and to address collective identity markers in Bruneian society.

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